



Centre for Accelerated Development

Policies or People?

A New Approach to Public Problem-Solving

Executive Summary

- This whitepaper explores the gap between policies and people and how it can be bridged by a new practice of public problem-solving that is people-centered, experimental, iterative, data-enabled, and designed to scale.
- It introduces the **Centre for Accelerated Development (CFAD)** framework by Sauramandala Foundation, which helps accelerate social and economic change in remote, vulnerable, and disconnected communities through collaborative action.
- It showcases some of the projects and outcomes of CFAD in various sectors, such as education, health, water, waste, and climate change, with a gender lens based on our work in Meghalaya over the last four years.
- It concludes with a call to action for policymakers, practitioners, funders, and researchers to join CFAD in creating a more inclusive and sustainable future for India's most marginalized communities.

Introduction

- India is facing many public problems that affect the lives and livelihoods of millions of its citizens. However, there is a disconnect between policy and ground reality in India, which causes the creation of well-intended policy that is disconnected from ground realities. This results in ineffective solutions, wasted resources, and missed opportunities for social impact. Climate change significantly affects India's health, food security, and livelihoods. As global temperatures rise, we will continue to see the country's poorest suffer the most as climate change destroys livelihoods while the gaps continue to widen. To address these issues, developing local contextual solutions and ecosystems that consider different communities' unique needs and challenges is important.
- However, there is also a ray of hope. Across India, government officials at all levels are adopting new ways to align policies with people's needs and aspirations. Alongside them, many NGOs and social entrepreneurs are taking matters into their own hands and creating direct-service solutions to address public problems such as poverty, malnutrition, education, and livelihoods. These efforts are not mere interventions; they are experiments to find effective ways to transform the lives of millions of Indians.
- But these efforts also face challenges such as lack of accessibility, data, and on-ground support. They also tend to operate in silos without leveraging the potential of collaboration and integration across sectors and stakeholders.
- There is a need for a new practice of public problem-solving that can bridge the gap between policies and people and create more effective and scalable solutions for India's most pressing challenges.



CFAD: A Practice of Public Problem-Solving

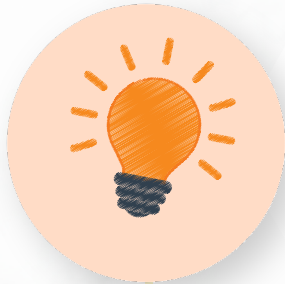
The Centre for Accelerated Development (CFAD) by Sauramandala Foundation is a public policy framework that addresses the challenges remote and inaccessible communities face by accelerating social and economic change through collaborative action¹.



CFAD follows a system's thinking and integration approach that consists of four common elements:

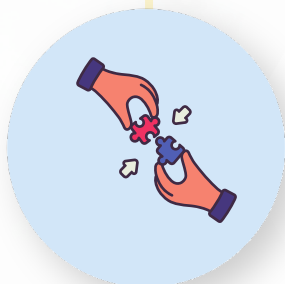
- Participatory Approach: puts people with needs and capabilities at the center of programs and policies (**human-centered design** and **lived experiences**)
- Contextual experimentation: start small and scout for local solutions, tests ideas, and concepts, shift to modular contracting, and experiment to generate evidence before larger implementation.
- Iterative: Constantly assess problems, monitor progress, and evaluate what works
- Designed to scale: assesses and plans for how to expand the impact and scale both independently and within the government system.

CFAD Approach - Iterative, nimble and insight-based



Gain insights and build social capital

This step involves spending time with the communities and system actors (teachers, farmers, Anganwadi workers, line departments) by living with them for an extended period and understanding their needs from their perspectives using techniques/frameworks such as ethnographic research, PRA (Participatory Rural Appraisal), need assessment, and root cause analysis. This helps build a report on the region with insights, gaps, and findings from the field.



Aggregate partners for collaborative action

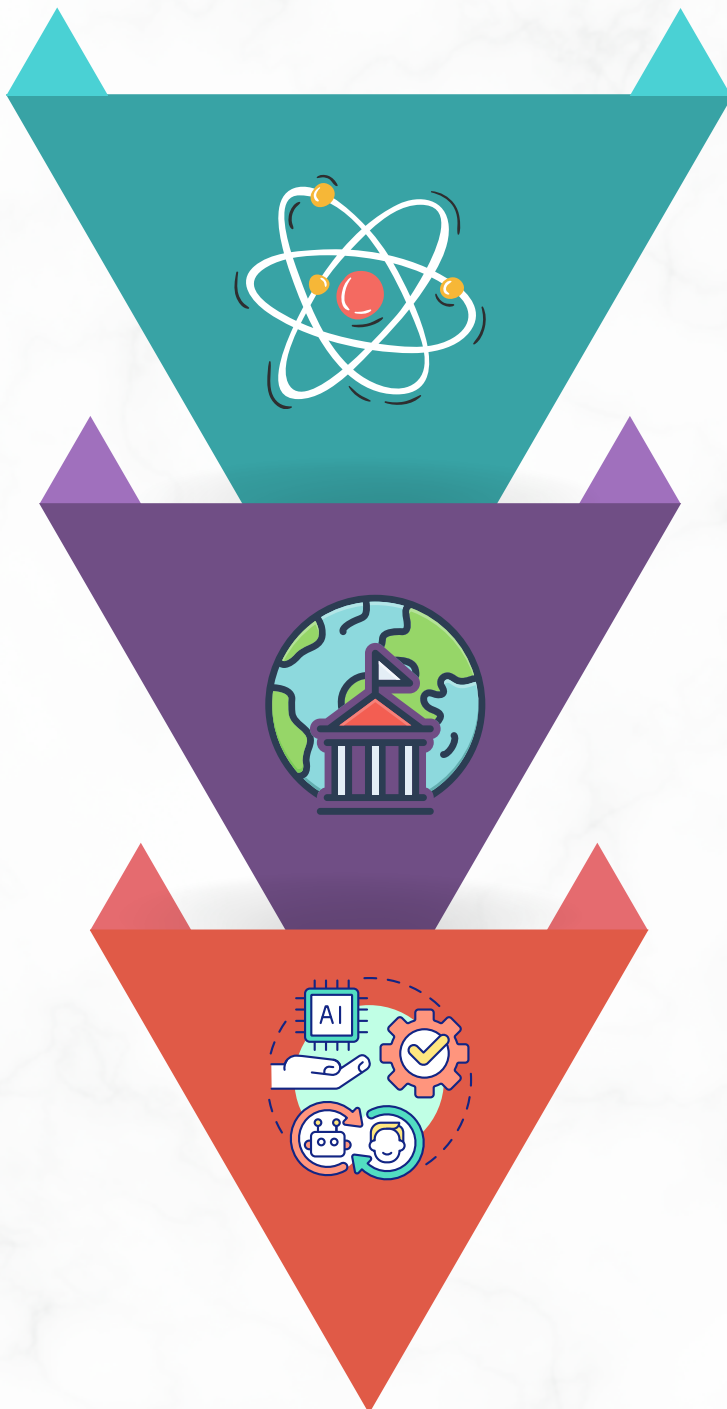
Based on the insights gained on the ground, we can match them to organizations that can address the problems and help improve the indicators, co-design pilots, and raise funds for implementation. In this step, we closely study the work done by other organizations to filter and select the best organizations based on the solution needed in the particular community and then facilitate the implementation of the projects with different partners across sectors using a system thinking approach to sequence the projects in the most efficient order.



Evidence generation and policy advocacy

We act as an aggregator to onboard partners to solve specific problems related to education, sustainable livelihood, health, entrepreneurship, water, waste, and climate change with a gender lens. Any learnings from the projects on the field are continuously presented to the government at the block, district, and state levels to advocate for replication and provide inputs on policy changes and design

CFAD Components - Where the bottom up meets the top down



A LEARNING LAYER

The foundational element of the ground-up CFAD is the learning layer, which offers valuable insights, inputs, and perspectives directly from the grassroots level. Within the CFAD learning layer, numerous development actors, including individuals, NGOs, and other solution providers, collaborate to design pilot projects, test ideas, and gather knowledge that aids in the scaling process.

A SECRETARIAT

The secretariat layer plays a pivotal role in enabling the CFAD approach to achieve impactful scalability. This layer possesses the potential to provide financial support as well as other crucial resources, facilitate outreach to the masses, and integrate policies effectively. Advocacy holds great importance within this layer. Key actors involved in this layer include District Commissioners, Principal and Chief Secretaries, and the Office of the Chief Minister.

A POOLED INNOVATION FUND

In the CFAD approach, it is recognized that access to flexible funding is crucial for fostering innovation and addressing societal challenges beyond project deliverables. This involves securing reliable financial support from various sources, including Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives, High-Net-Worth Individuals, Foundations, and other funding partners. The key emphasis lies on obtaining flexible funding that allows for adaptability and creative problem-solving.

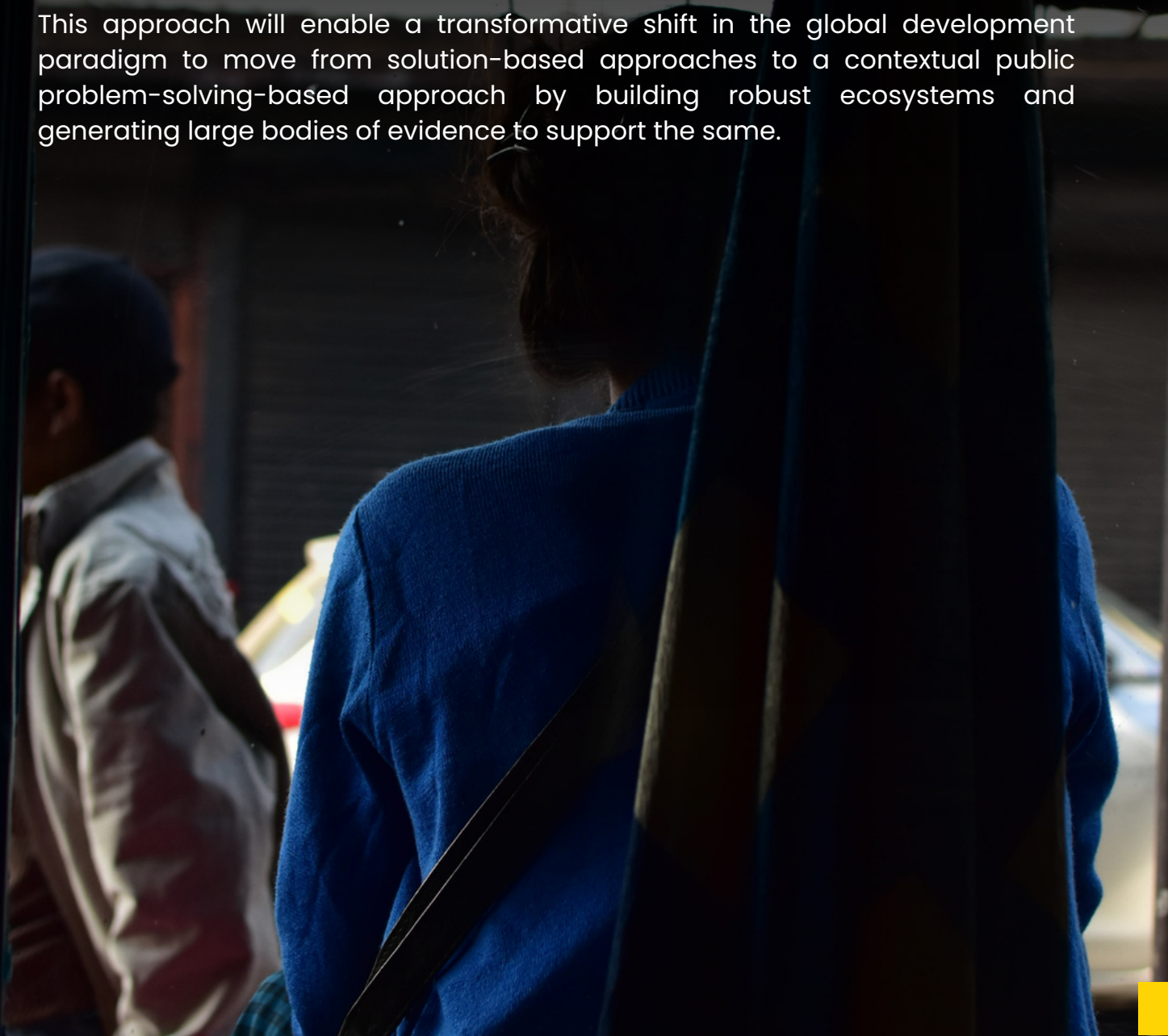
Need for CFAD Approach

At CFAD, we recognize the need for a shift in approach. Increasing participation, localizing solutions, and fostering collaboration will reduce risks and empower communities. We aim to build an ecosystem within each community, investing time, resources, and effort to enhance their resilience and capacity.

While our initial focus is on remote and vulnerable communities, our ultimate goal is to create a large-scale impact. Through partnerships with governments and development actors, we strive to take the essence of the CFAD approach and extend it to other regions. We firmly believe that this approach is applicable not only in remote areas but also in rural and urban settings.

By building ecosystems, promoting participation, and tailoring solutions to the local context, we can create lasting change and improve the well-being of communities. CFAD is committed to this mission and invites you to join us in our journey toward creating a more resilient and inclusive future.

This approach will enable a transformative shift in the global development paradigm to move from solution-based approaches to a contextual public problem-solving-based approach by building robust ecosystems and generating large bodies of evidence to support the same.



Projects and Outcomes of CFAD

Our projects originate from the firsthand experiences of individuals and communities residing on the fringes of society and those actively involved in addressing these challenges. It is a process that entails understanding the complexities of the problems and striving to resolve them through human-centered design principles.

The CFAD approach, consisting of three stages, results from this ongoing endeavor. It involves reflecting on the problem statements, acquiring knowledge, fostering innovation, and developing solutions that can significantly impact a large scale.

CFAD has successfully extended its reach to communities in all 12 districts of Meghalaya through various implemented projects while directly unlocking over USD 2 million in government funding in the last FY and influencing over USD 15 million of public and philanthropic capital. While some projects are still in their initial pilot stages, others have progressed to a policy-level scale. The valuable insights gained from these projects have been utilized to expand the initiatives and provide policy recommendations for further impact.

Some of the projects that CFAD has facilitated or implemented are:

PRIME-Sauramanadala Rural Entrepreneurship Fellowship

120+

Rural entrepreneurs supported so far with a goal to support over 300+

Partners



Problem Statement

Non-existent ecosystem to support entrepreneurs at the last mile across themes like access to capital, mentoring, branding, market linkage, etc.

Domain Area

Rural Entrepreneurship & Livelihoods

Chief Minister's Youth Centres, Meghalaya

1100+

Rural youth registered
as learners so far
across 22 centres

Partners



Problem Statement

Lack of open learning spaces in rural
Meghalaya

Domain Area

Self-directed learning and safe spaces

The Forgotten Folklore Project

45

Contextualized
storybooks for early
learners

Partners



Problem Statement

Children's books lack contextualized
content, impacting their ability to relate
and learn.

Domain Area

Early Childhood Development

Health Energy Nexus

440+

Health centres solar
electrified and
equipped with energy
efficient equipment
by the end of 2024

Partners



Problem Statement

Rural communities lacked access to upgraded medical equipment at primary healthcare facilities. There is a lack of energy to power the system, and healthcare workers' skills need to be updated.

Domain Area

Health & Alternate Energy

Meghalaya Health System Strengthening System

300

Technical assistance and
participatory design to
influence policy
implementation for 300+
health centres

Partners



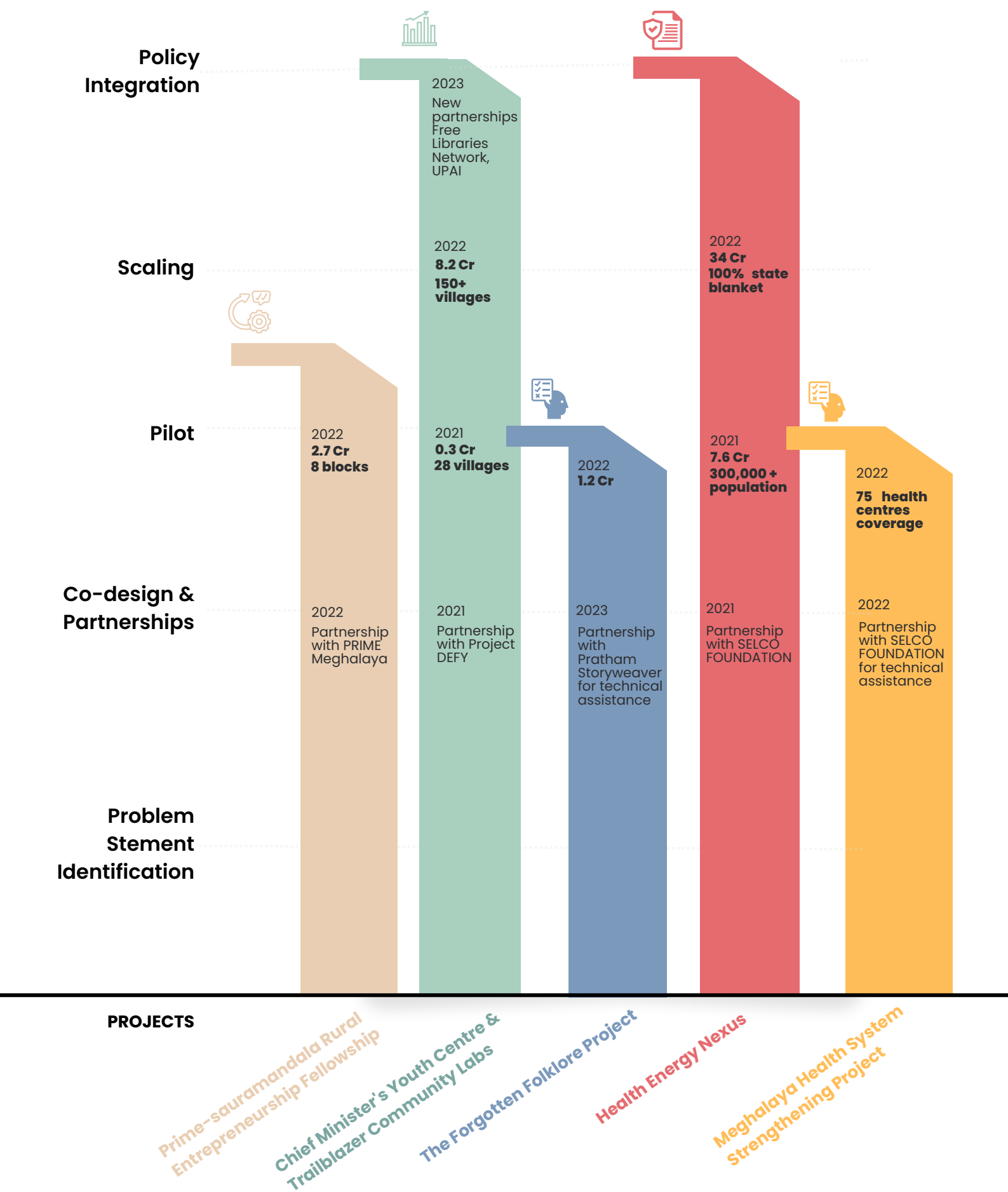
Problem Statement

Currently, designed healthcare facilities are vulnerable to climate impacts, affecting workers and the community.

Domain Area

Climate Sustainability & Health

CFAD Approach - Reflection in our Projects



The CFAD framework by Sauramandala Foundation bridges the gap between policies and people through a people-centred, experimental, data-enabled, and scalable approach to public problem-solving. This whitepaper showcases the transformative impact of CFAD in sectors like education, health, water, waste, and climate change, with a gender lens.

We invite policymakers, practitioners, funders, NGOs, and researchers to join us in creating an inclusive ecosystem for public problem-solving in India. By adopting CFAD, we can accelerate social and economic change in remote, vulnerable, and disconnected communities through collaborative action.

We can build a more inclusive and sustainable future for India's marginalized communities. Join us in leveraging local knowledge, resources, and expertise to address the unique challenges faced by these communities.

Let's collaborate, contribute resources, and develop innovative solutions that empower communities and amplify their voices. Together, we can shape policies rooted in the lived experiences and aspirations of the people they serve.

Join us in creating a future where the gap between policies and people is effectively bridged, communities drive their development, and everyone's potential is realized.

To know more or to partner with us, visit:



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[/sauramandalafoundation](https://sauramandalafoundation)

